

composers. In the world of jazz, African American women such as Billie Holiday and Eartha Kitt had a huge impact on the genre. From the mid-20th century onward, women wrote and performed in a diverse range of genres. Pop artists, such as Madonna, attained megastar status and became influential role models. Today, many pop stars, including Lady Gaga, speak out about gender discrimination in the business side of the music industry, and use their music to advocate for women's rights.

“I’m **over** being a **pop star**. I don’t wanna be a **hot girl**. I wanna be **iconic**.”

BEYONCÉ, SINGER-SONGWRITER



▼ Girl power

British girl group the Spice Girls, pictured here at the Brit Awards in 1997, were an iconic pop group who popularized feminism as “girl power,” while embracing their sexuality and the power of strong female friendships.



PROFILES

MUSIC MAKERS

Kassia (c. 9th century) came from a noble family and was a potential spouse for Byzantine Emperor Theophilus. Instead, she chose to found her own convent where she composed liturgical music. Many of the works ascribed to her remain questionable; however, she is best known for the Mary Magdalene hymn that retains a position of prominence within the Orthodox Church of Greece.

Hildegard von Bingen (1098–1179) was a German abbess, scientist, theologian, author, and composer. One of the only known medieval women composers, her music consists of melodies with Latin texts used for sacred worship. Her most significant work today remains *Ordo Virtutum* (*Play of the Virtues*) (c.1151), the earliest surviving morality play for which she wrote both text and music.

Clara Schumann (1819–1896) was a pianist child prodigy. Her extensive concert touring and flawless technique garnered her respect equal to that earned by her male contemporaries. Her contributions to piano recital were long-lasting; she performed without music and played only solo piano music, a rarity for concerts in her lifetime.

Nadia Boulanger (1887–1979) was the most influential musical pedagogue of the 20th century. Although she stopped composing after the death of her sister, Lili, her renown was such that many flocked to France to study with her. Her students were some of the most prominent composers of the century, including Aaron Copland, Thea Musgrave, Philip Glass, and Leonard Bernstein.

Billie Holiday (1915–1959) is one of the most notable jazz singers of all time. Overcoming a difficult childhood, she rose to great acclaim despite a lack of formal music education. At the height of her career she collaborated with Count Basie, Benny Goodman, and Artie Shaw. Her most significant recording, “Strange Fruit,” recounts the racism of the southern United States and remains one of the most important American songs of the 20th century.

Marin Alsop (b. 1956) is the first female conductor of a major American orchestra, the Baltimore Symphony Orchestra, an appointment granted in 2007. She studied conducting under both Leonard Bernstein and Seiji Ozawa, and is known primarily for her devotion to contemporary American music. Alsop has conducted many ensembles including the London Philharmonic Orchestra.